

The games column

Worlds within worlds Interesting, mind-bending puzzles abound in *Cocoon* – some so clever they will make you gasp. With visuals reminiscent of H. R. Giger, don't miss out on one of the biggest gaming treats of the year, says **Jacob Aron**



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ANNAPURNA INTERACTIVE

Cocoon's visual style is that of H.R. Giger let loose with a colour palette

within the world that aren't relevant to the current puzzle are quietly closed off, making it clear exactly where you should focus attention. It is like the developer is sitting beside you, saying: "Don't worry about that bit, look at these bits here. Rearrange the pieces – you can do it!"

As such, I was never frustrated playing *Cocoon*, though I certainly found myself challenged on many occasions throughout the game's 4-to-5-hour duration. A couple of puzzles literally made me gasp at how clever they were, and how clever I felt when I solved them.

In fact, smart choices abound throughout. The controls are stunningly simple, with just movement and a single button for interaction. Initially, I thought this would limit the complexity of the puzzles – even the 1980s *Super Mario Bros.* gives you two buttons – but instead it means you can concentrate on figuring out solutions, rather than struggling to execute them with fiddly controls. Failing to beat a boss doesn't kill you, but boots you out of your current sphere. Again, I heard the developer: "Well, you didn't manage it this time, but have another go!" Most tellingly, the game doesn't work through all the possible permutations of its sphere powers and worlds – something a lesser developer might have felt the need to do, at the cost of quality.

It is difficult to talk about *Cocoon's* specifics without spoiling it, but really, if I haven't sold you on this game by now, I probably never will. If so, I'm sorry, as failing to play *Cocoon* would mean missing out on one of the biggest gaming treats of the year. ■



Game

Cocoon

Geometric Interactive

PC, PlayStation 4 and 5, Xbox One and Series X/S, Nintendo Switch

Jacob also recommends...

Game

Hollow Knight

Team Cherry

PC, PlayStation 4, Xbox One, Nintendo Switch

With more of a focus on combat and exploration, this isn't really a puzzle game in the same way as Cocoon, but its world design shares a love of creepy crawlies.

I AM a sucker for video games that explore unusual geometries, creating fun by playing with the nature of space itself. It is no surprise, then, that I loved *Cocoon*, which turned my brain inside out, upside down and through other spatial transformations probably best not mentioned outside of advanced, degree-level maths.

The game starts with a humanoid-looking insect being birthed from a cybernetic cocoon. You take control of it and wander around a desert landscape dotted with equipment that is a blend of biological and mechanical – *Cocoon's* visual style is that of artist H. R. Giger of *Alien* fame let loose with an actual colour palette. With no dialogue, there is little story to speak of, but the atmosphere is incredible, whether you are traversing paths that look like delicate insect wings or watching a beetle-inspired door to a new location gradually unfurl.

Early levels see you solve a variety of puzzles involving accessing and hitting switches that at first seem out of reach, but after besting an angry wasp

robot, *Cocoon* starts revealing its hidden treasures.

The game's core mechanic involves picking up glowing spheres that give you powers that help you navigate the world you initially find yourself in, such as revealing hidden paths. This gets more complex: you can also enter the spheres to uncover new

"You wander around a desert landscape dotted with equipment that is a blend of biological and mechanical"

worlds to explore. Crucially, you can bring one sphere into another, allowing you to exploit its power in the interior world and trace a path through interlocking spaces.

This key twist opens up a huge variety of interesting, mind-bending puzzles. Each time *Cocoon* escalated in complexity, I was taken aback by the inventiveness of the new ideas I was being asked to explore. Importantly, the game is never unfair. In a brilliant move, paths